

The mind-body problem

Critics of mind–body dualism pointed to a flaw in Descartes’s theory. He maintained that mind and matter are essentially different: physical substance is material and incapable of thought, while mental substance is immaterial and does not exist in space. But we know from experience that the two interact: mental events bring about physical ones, and vice versa. There must be a connection between the two worlds – but where is it, and what is the nature of their interaction?

Descartes suggested it must happen somewhere in the brain, but this does not resolve the problem, as the brain is a physical object, separate from the immaterial mind in dualist theory. Others suggested that God forms the connection. For many philosophers, however, the mind-body problem led to a rejection of dualism in favour of some form of monism: that everything is either fundamentally physical (physicalism, or materialism), or immaterial (idealism). Spinoza proposed a theory incorporating aspects of both dualism and monism (see [Spinoza: substance and attributes](#)).

Dualism	Monism
Cartesian dualism Matter and mind are both equal and fundamental – neither is subordinate to the other. 	Physicalism Everything is essentially physical in nature. 
	Idealism Physical matter is subsidiary to the Ideals of the mind. 
	'Neutral monism' A third substance manifests itself as both matter and mind. 